

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 3
Painting the Stars ~ Imagining a Future
20 September 2026

Preaching: LVF

Worship Leading: ML, Laude, and Ayur Barduev

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

Improvisation on SERVANT SONG and TALLIS' CANON

Across The Stars (John Williams, arr. C. Bull)

Cornfield Chase from *Interstellar* (Hans Zimmer, arr. Anna Lapwood)

Wie schön leuchtet der Morgenstern/How Brightly Shines The Morning Star:

- Hymn by Philipp Nicolai
- Setting by Dietrich Buxtehude
- Setting by Johann Pachelbel
- Improvisation

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Michael and Laude center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Welcome this morning to First Church. Your presence both here and online enriches us and our time together. As we gather, welcoming all to this place, let us open our whole selves as we listen closely to these mystical words from the Bengali poet, Tagore.

Words of Gathering

Members of Laude

Scott:

The ancient ones saw it this way:

In the beginning, the Holy One allowed the light,
'Let there be light,'
and from Spirit's being,
radiance emerged
that lit creation's path toward its sacred future.

Molly:

The scientists see it this way:

In the beginning, from the darkness and emptiness
of nothingness,
an unaccountable explosion of radiation
expanded outward in all directions,
which now our measurements can measure.

Kion:

The first disciples saw it this way:

Jesus, too, allowed the light to brighten
dark death's reign,
announcing a new creation,
brightened by justice for all.

Ianthe:

We might look at it this way:

That same light that shone in Jesus shines now
through us,
and whether this becomes real to us – or not –
depends on whether we allow an eternal shining
to light our path
into a future that awaits
our distinctive stamp.

TUTTI VOICES: Let there be light. [adapt/bsanguin]

Ianthe: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.*

***Hymn of Gathering** *Creator God You Gave Us Life* TALLIS' CANON

Creator God, you gave us life, your image formed within our souls,
Yet through the mist of time and space, we search for that which makes us whole.

In every flower and every tree, we see your great diversity,
Yet greater still we see your love, expressed in our humanity.

When with our hearts, our hands, our minds, we share our gifts with all the world,
Our spirits soar beyond the veil, to touch the very face of God.

Through hands that paint majestic skies, and voices chanting melody,
With words that reach beyond the page, we comprehend your mystery.

[Michael center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness**

Let us pray:

ML

All things are born of you, O God.
We carry within us your light and your life.

In the mystery of matter
and deep in the cells of our souls
are your longings for oneness.

The oneness of the universe
vast and vibrating with the sound of its beginning.

The oneness of the earth
greening and teaming as a single body.

The oneness of the human soul
a sacred countenance in infinite form.

*As we consider the beauty
of this earth and our life together,
grant us your longings for oneness, O God,
amidst all life's glorious multiplicities.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

Rise Up, My Love!

Eleanor Daley

Text: Song of Solomon 2:10–13

Tiffany Ho, Molly Pease, Anna Caplan, Ianthe Marini, *Quartet*

*Rise up, my Love, my fair one, and come away. For lo! The winter has passed, the rain is over
and gone. The flowers appear upon the earth, the time of the singing of birds is come.*

[Ayur to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

AB

I invite you to pray with me this version of The Lord's Prayer, a poetic translation from the Aramaic, the language that Jesus spoke:

*O Breathing Life, your Name shines everywhere!
Release a space to plant your Presence here.
Imagine your possibilities now.
Embody your desire in every light and form.
Grow through us this moment's bread and wisdom.
Untie the knots of failure binding us,
as we release the strands we hold of others' faults.
Help us not forget our Source.
Yet free us from not being in the Present.
From you arises every Vision, Power, and Song,
from gathering to gathering.
Amen.*

[–translation from the Aramaic]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

In this world of differences
we are challenged to see the sacred
in many faces and many traditions.

In this world of options,
we are challenged to remain true to what we know
of that sacredness, of ourselves, of those we love.

In this world of blessing,
we know gifts of beauty and wonder
and seek to ground them in all holiness.

May the differences we find this day
bless us with a deep and sustained
awareness of the presence of the sacred
in our oft-confusing world.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[Ayur to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition

AB

Hear now A Reading from Psalm 1 ~ A 21st Century Exploration by Francis Macnab

There are many pathways in front of us.
We see some people take pathways that turn-out
to be destructive and unhealthy.
But our happiness and well-being depend on us
taking the pathways that keep us connected
with the best purposes
and with the best spirit.

Look carefully at the tree that flourishes beside the river -
its leaves are healthy and it bears fruit in season.
We can be like the tree.
But we can forget all that and become
like chaff blown in all directions by the wind.

God of all life has created in us a desire to be the best we can be.
When we follow that desire,
our whole being is strongly affirmed.
But when we become indifferent to that desire,
we lose our connection with the best purposes
and the best spirit. [FMacnab/fwb]

This is the witness of the people.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph short transition ML center cancel]

Prayers with the People

ML

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

In these moments, as we turn to the Holy One,
may the ebb and flow of our thinking
settle into stillness.
May each heaviness we carry
be released into the Divine love.
May the rhythm of our breathing
restore a spaciousness within.
May we let go that which needs let go today,
as we make way for tomorrow.
May we listen gently enough
to feel the wonder and mystery of God's presence
And welcome God's re-creation in our lives.

As we share these moments of silence, we are invited to write the prayers of our hearts
for our lives and the life of our world on the slips of paper in our programs. If you are
online, please share your prayers by emailing prayers@fccla.org.

Then, as the music begins, we are invited to come forward to share our prayers here in
the bowl, and to light candles signifying our prayers, for ourselves, those we love and
hold dear - and for the life of the world.

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Creating God,
what incredible diversity exists in our world –
in nature, in our bodies, in our beliefs.
We live along the invisible line
that runs between
the ‘this’ and ‘that’ of our existence,
shifting our choices,
developing our ideas,
bending to the wisdom of those
whose perspectives we value.

*May we ever seek and celebrate
the truths discovered along
a line illuminated by the best of who we are,
what we think,
what we value.*

And may we hold to that line,
ever loving into the best of who we are and may be.

*As those born into light,
yet ever seeking it,
we pray.
Amen and Amen.*

[adapt/gvosper]

[Christoph transition for choir]

Meditation Anthem

The Lord is my Shepherd

John Rutter
Text: Psalm 23

Rohan Ramanan, *Oboe*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon

Imagining a Future

LVF

[Christoph transition Ayur to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

AB

In the beginning all things were created
and God said they were good.
At our beginning, we were created of God,
known to God, and treasured by God.
In every new beginning, God is still with us –
creating, transforming, renewing –
calling us into relationship with God’s Self,

with each other, and with all of creation.

We have the opportunity to respond to this miracle
by living lives of simplicity and sustainability
and creating hope – even in the midst of despair.
With our offerings this morning,
we pledge to believe that we can make a difference
as we act for justice...and the healing of the earth.

Today, we share our offerings with our Community Gardens & Urban Farm here at the Cathedral. These spaces across our 5-acre campus have been intentionally transformed for the growing and sharing of food with our beloved neighbors across Koreatown and Westlake. This food, chosen specifically for the culinary traditions of our neighbors, includes: over 60 fruit trees, a medicinal, culinary, and butterfly garden with herbs for cooking, healing, and struggling Monarch populations, and over 30 raised beds containing varieties of greens and healthy vegetables.

Our Gardens & Farm also serve as educational spaces for local area schools and organizations like HOLA, and are more frequently being used as space for nurturing spirituality, community, and reconnection with the earth.

Thank you for joining us in this expansive vision, as we become the best neighbors we can be in our neighborhood.

Gardens QR Code

Offertory Anthem

Two Falling Stars

Paul John Rudoi Text: HAFIZ

Laude, Anna Caplan and Kion Heidari, Duet, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Conductor

Let us be like two falling stars in the day sky. Let no one know of our sublime beauty as we hold hands with God. And burn into a sacred existence that defies – that surpasses – every description of ecstasy and love.

[All turn towards altar]

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Ayur to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Offering Prayer**

AB

Let us join our voices together in prayer:

*God our Creator,
you have made us one with this earth,
to tend it and to bring forth the fruit of our labor;
may we so respect and cherish
all that has life from you,
that we will continually share
all that we are and all that we have,
to bring forth your dream for our world.
Amen and Amen. Please be seated.*

[Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church

LVF

-Mention events in program inserts

-Join us next Sunday as our Fall Series, *Painting the Stars*, continues with the theme, *An Anticipatory Universe*.

-This Saturday, Sept. 26, we have the privilege of welcoming Mother Agapia, a Russian Orthodox nun who has spent her life in Jerusalem. She will speak to the current realities of Christians and Palestinians more broadly. That free event happens at 11am in Shatto Chapel.

-And then that evening, join us for a special "Music in the Gardens" event from 4-7pm, featuring musicians in our community. Stop by the Gardens table today to learn more.

-We are giving thanks today for our faithful Food@First team nurturing community with our neighbors through the sharing of food. We also give thanks for our amazing Gardens team whose harvest this morning from our Community Gardens and Urban Farm is also shared. They also hosted a major workday yesterday!

-This Wednesday, Men's Group will resume their monthly meetings, 7-9pm, in person at the church, as will Not Your Grandma's Bible Study this Thursday at 6pm, both in person and on zoom.

-Join us for Coffee Hour today in Mayflower Courtyard! Also, Laurie Dill is offering another tour of our Community Gardens & Urban Farm- an opportunity to see these incredible spaces built for the growing and sharing of food, and a sensory, hands-on tour, as well.

Words of Blessing

LVF

May the Holy One,
who never ceases to practice
the art of creating,
keep us ever

at the edge of our skills,
our habits,
our vision,
that we may never
grow so content
in our creating
that we miss the God
who is ever about
to do a new thing.
[janrichardson]

Choral Response

As One Sky

Paul John Rudoi
Text: Kabir

*Day and night, the chorus of music fills the heavens:
The light of the sun, the moon, and the stars shines bright. The melody of love swells forth.*

***Hymn for the Journey**

God of Unexplored Tomorrows

THE SERVANT SONG

God of unexplored tomorrows,
of today and yesterday,
God of rock and flowing river,
be our refuge, be our way.

Guardian rock above, before us,
strong foundation where we build,
landmark through the haze of doubting,
shelter where our fears are stilled,

Be the cleansing, quenching water,
irrigate, disturb and move,
stir us from our easy shallows,
current of refreshing love.

God of rock and flowing river
now and ever with us stand,
to transform our land of promise
into each one's promised land. [bjones]

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Cornfield Chase from *Interstellar* - Reprise (Hans Zimmer, arr. Anna Lapwood)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music

Dr. Ianthe Marini

Our musical texts today are written by ancient poets in the wisdoms of world traditions: the *Song of Solomon* and *Psalm 23* both from the Hebrew Scriptures, *Two Falling Stars* by the 14th century Persian mystic Hafiz, and *As One Sky* by the 15th century Indian mystic Kabir, whose writings are found in the Hindu, Sikh, and Sufi traditions.

As we continue to explore the interconnectedness of our lives in this autumnal series, we remember that it is from the rich diversity of our Sacred Earth that we are created, nurtured, and sustained, and to that same Earth that we are welcomed back home. Today, as our theme invites us to *paint the stars and imagine a future*, we learn from the textual wisdom of the ancient teachers who knew how to live from the Earth, recognizing that any future we foresee must be in reverence and in sacred communion with Her.

The textual imagery of the day is set evocatively to music: first by Eleanor Daley in our introit, whose four part setting for treble voices of the *Song of Solomon* invokes the sacredness of the Divine Feminine — her ebb and flow, her beckoning us back into our bodies which were created in love. And then in the 23rd Psalm set by John Rutter, whose use of the oboe—an instrument made of wood creating sound by human air vibrating through nature's reed—paints pastoral pictures of a symbiotic relationship between the human, spiritual, and natural worlds. The ancient psalm reminding us that from the Earth we have all we need, and indeed, our cup overflows.

In offertory we explore the vivid poetry of Hafiz set by Paul John Rudoi in his cycle *Song of Sky and Sea: A Song of Realization* as we find that it is through nature that we hold hands with God, creating sacred existence together—that through this relationship in Nature we find that we even *surpass* our defining of love. And finally, with the mystic poetry of Kabir, from Rudoi's same cycle, we sing that through the light of sun, moon, and stars, Divine Love swells. In our current climate crisis and gross misuse of the planet's resources, we imagine a future today by remembering that it is only possible through our committed protection and radical care of the Sacred Earth.